



THE FIGHT FOR AMERICA'S FAMILIES

Exposing the Corruption in Family Courts and CPS.

They took my kids. They tried to silence me. They WON'T.

FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 28

NORTH CAROLINA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside North Carolina's family courts and child-welfare system.

103

NORTH CAROLINA FAMILIES ON
RECORD · 152 CHILDREN IMPACTED ·
18 MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST
OF PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED
MAY 9, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
40 OF 100

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS · NORTH CAROLINA

A name appears below only after 3 or more independent families have named the same actor in North Carolina. Submitter names, emails, and contact details are never published. Comments below are direct family reports — one per family — with all identifying information removed.

Tammy SmithATTORNEY (OPPOSING) · HARNETT COUNTY · **3 FAMILIES**

"She was texting the judge from a personal number during the hearing about the hearing itself. He would check his phone after every single text she sent in the court room. And they would lock eyes and nod." **HARNETT**

"Refused to make copies (in the chambers) of evidence that the trial judge Rose asked, continued to question myself about My spouse but would not subpoena My spouse to ask the questions."

"Delay after delay. Inappropriate with the judge"

Public threshold rule: Names are grouped conservatively by normalized spelling, role, and location. Common titles, punctuation, casing, and middle initials collapse together. Close misspellings are not auto-merged without admin review. Only family-direct submissions count toward the public threshold.

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

NORTH CAROLINA AT A GLANCE.

Across 103 North Carolina families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 152 102 of 103 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$133,800 median across 31 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 18 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 52.4% 31.1% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 103	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.5	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 102 of 103	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 40

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so North Carolina families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

03 THE COST OF NORTH CAROLINA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	58	\$10,000	\$47,768	\$2,770,555
Lost Wages	47	\$12,000	\$82,119	\$3,859,600
Other Court Fees	25	\$1,000	\$23,840	\$596,000
Therapy / Evaluations	37	\$1,000	\$8,814	\$326,100
Reunification Services	27	\$400	\$2,014	\$54,375
GAL Fees	20	\$0	\$412	\$8,250
Asset Loss ¹	38	\$26,000	—	—
Median Family Burden (31 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$133,800	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$26,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME - MONTHS

Median months lost	
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04 WHO IS REPORTING · NORTH CAROLINA

Most families documenting in North Carolina are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		47	46%
Not provided		26	25%
Case closed: within last 2 years		12	12%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		9	9%
Active case: progress being made		5	5%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		44	43%
Family Court Only		32	31%
Unknown		19	18%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		7	7%
Family Court		1	1%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		18	17%
3 – 5 years		17	17%
5 – 10 years		16	16%
Over 10 years		15	15%
5+ years		10	10%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		27	26%
Visitation Only		22	21%
50/50 Joint		21	20%
Children in Foster Care		12	12%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		10	10%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Mecklenburg		7	7%
Buncombe		6	6%
Wake		5	5%
Johnston		4	4%
Harnett		4	4%
Burke		4	4%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		32	31%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		14	14%
High Conflict Divorce		9	9%
Other: (Short answer)		9	9%
Other		8	8%

05 PARENT VOICES — NORTH CAROLINA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable North Carolina comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



They destroyed my family abused my children and sold them for bonuses and profit from me and adopted them out to strangers

— AIMEE

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

My ex made false allegations which led (With the recommendation and advice give by CPS) to the no contact ex parte order of my child without any hearing or trial be held. Also, Corruption and Harrasement within the county caused constitutional laws to be broken.

— NORTH CAROLINA PARENT · AARON

MORE VOICES FROM NORTH CAROLINA

The corrupt family court system has enabled the mother of my children to keep my children away from me for the last 6 years and has caused unimaginable pain for them and myself and has stolen years that we will never get back!

— GAVIN

The system has completely tore my family apart. Leaving my kids in a home full of chaos and abuse.We are beyond traumatized.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Completely ignores other possible family members to place the children so they can keep them in custody. Violation of Rights Under Color of Law

— DERREKA

There were constant theats of making my life miserable if i ever left . However Never in a million years did I ever think with my ex knowing his status of being sterile he would attempt to kidnap my child with the courts help much less get away with it. using the courts to gain [...]

— ANITA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They took my life away. My husband and mother both committed suicide over the lose. I morn my children everyday and they are still alive

— ANGEL

CPS allows physical and verbal abuse on mothers along with selling my children through child trafficking. That is not child safety, that is abuse on our children and mothers.

— ALLISON

DSS with the help of my immigrant ex-wife not able to speak english the case worker fabricated false statements to build a case against me destroying our family. A corrupt evil DSS supervisor in charge said to me you did something wrong. DSS/JUDGE/GAL threaten brainwashed [...]

— FEDERICO

It has destroyed my kids. Plan and simple while leaving me broke from just trying to be a dad.

— JP

Ripped my world away broke my heart because I'm seeing now my children are suffering and being neglected from their own father.

— AMANDA

My kids have already lost one parent. Now cps is helping them lose another. This is inhumane

— LEAH

They destroyed the life my children and I had. I now have no life with my children.

— STEPHANIE

The court has destroyed my family and my children childhood and mental well being.

— CATHY

Lenoir county DSS came into our lives with the notion that they were there to help us rebuild after a brutal and traumatic experience. Instead,they came in and completely ripped my family apart . Slandered my name and character. Caused my kids emotional, mental, and even [...]

— SYDNI

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Judge was horrible- would not listen, finalized order that put me out of house and home. And my kids best interest not considered in the slightest.

— JENNIFER

Ripped us into shreds, torn us.. broken us.. hurt us so badly. Traumatized my children to where they NEEDED therapy & things they NEVER needed PRIOR. Yet they use that as reason to KEEP THEM. Altered my records & my husband's, demanding things from our jobs which caused us to be [...]

— BRITTANY

Taken my children's mother away with judges that won't make decisions and forensic interviews that are never read. I feel like nobody cares but me.

— VALERIE

This system has destroyed the soul of a child, her father's grief cannot be put into words, our children have missed out on months, if not years of having their own parents mentally healthy due to the stress and trauma, they have endured trauma of their own due to living with a [...]

— ERIN

Abused my child, incarcerated me twice, made me pay opposing counsel fees, denied me a court appointed attorney for Contempt, took my child away, retaliated.

— JACQUELYN

My boys that I raised alone were instantly ripped from their mother and have been told horrible untrue things about me to try and turn them against me. After domestic violence testimony and tons of evidence the judge still took my babies.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court was a nightmare that felt as though it would never end. It nearly killed me. It tore our family apart and left my daughters (both) destroyed with PTSD on top of the abuse their father did to them- then family court punished them even further.

— JENNIFER

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Compete and utter destruction and trauma along with PTSD. Allowing a Narcissist to almost destroy my kids by trying to emotionally, financially and physically ruin me.

— JENNIFER

This system didn't just fail my family — it systematically punished me for protecting my children, tore them from their mother, and caused irreversible trauma under the guise of 'justice.' What was done to us wasn't protection; it was sanctioned harm.

— HOLLY

The system has caused irreversible trauma and stress. There have been delays on plans for our family and home renovations.

— STEVEN

They have destroyed our family! Gave my boys to a monster who is in jail awaiting trial for unaliving my oldest son n now my 2 other boys are back in state custody with no contact. I was always supposed to be kept in thier lives . This was a reunification case not adoption !

— FELICIA

has gave him temp custody he has no car no job etc and i moved back judge won't grant a ex parte even thou he could be in another state kids haven't talked me in 3 n half weeks . i been back since dec 12 still haven't seen them. oh and the 6yr old supposed have started school.

— TAYLOR

CPS took advantage of my depression and used it as a tool for attempted murder! Completely annihilated my family.

— NICOLE

No due process from a cheating spouse, quick Absolute-Divorce within months (lied about timeframe). Created hostile environment after divorce and used false allegations and "mean words" to secure DVPO; limiting access to son. Alienation has been used to make some hate his father [...]

— SHAUN

Ripped it apart. Took a part of me away and ill never be the same until i get them back

— ERICA

Avery county department of social services have destroyed my entire life for their financial gain. They never had our families best interest and defnately not my children's

— CARRIE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Separated children from the place they were born and loved. Alienated them and made me chose work or visitation. Lost my job. More alienation.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system is coming to my home and in my life and myself and my children and have completely changed our spirits our personalities and the way we view life. We won't constantly in fear everyday not knowing if we're going to be separated or what we're going to be facing if we're [...]

— SARA

The system has stolen time and been completely unjust to my child, my family and myself, and not doing what is best for the minor child's interest.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has ripped our family apart and gave my kids to foster families where theybe been molsted and tried to tell me they were doing whats best for my kids...i wanted to make them go thru what they made my kids and i go thru really but wven tho have wronged us so bad im not that [...]

— EMILY

They stole my children my home tore apart everything I worked for used my past against me as weapon and my emotional vunerlabilty as a weapon and threaten they would get adopted out in the next trial if I did not sign my rights over.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Parental Allination, Fraser accusations, things were said to the child that weren't true,narcissist abuser

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My son was always so happy, he had a glow about him from birth and was always smiling, such a healthy, happy, big baby boy. And when CPS ripped him out of my arms, the traumatic cry he let out is something I'll never forget. They admitted all he did was cry for 2 weeks straight [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

70 North Carolina parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 38 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — NORTH CAROLINA

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from North Carolina families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

They destroyed my family abused my children and sold them for bonuses and profit from me and adopted them out to strangers

— AIMEE

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There were constant theats of making my life miserable if i ever left . However Never in a million years did I ever think with my ex knowing his status of being sterile he would attempt to kidnap my child with the courts help much less get away with it. using the courts to gain coercive control, custody of a child he knew wasn't his. These people have ruined me, my family perspective on fair and equal justice. Left to suffer in silence ,captivity my son physical, mental and psychological trauma from this nightmare will have longterm impact well into adulthood. This system has destroyed my children bonds , a sense of being whole and our family bond. Causing unnecessary, undeserving stress, Confusion and great distrust with this grave travesty of justice,division of our family causing daily emotional struggles

— ANITA

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

They took my life away. My husband and mother both committed suicide over the lose. I morn my children everyday and they are still alive

— ANGEL

CPS allows physical and verbal abuse on mothers along with selling my children through child trafficking. That is not child safety, that is abuse on our children and mothers.

— ALLISON

DSS with the help of my immigrant ex-wife not able to speak english the case worker fabricated false statements to build a case against me destroying our family. A corrupt evil DSS supervisor in charge said to me you did something wrong. DSS/JUDGE/GAL threaten brainwashed tortured my wife and child putting the baby child into foster care because my wife wanted to correct the written allegation she had wrote and copy from DSS in english. Note: My wife could not read, speak or write in english. Total family destruction not repairable..

— FEDERICO

It has destroyed my kids. Plan and simple while leaving me broke from just trying to be a dad.

— JP

Ripped my world away broke my heart because I'm seeing now my children are suffering and being neglected from their own father.

— AMANDA

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— SYDNI

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— ERIN

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— SARA

The system has stolen time and been completely unjust to my child, my family and myself, and not doing what is best for the minor child's interest.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has ripped our family apart and gave my kids to foster families where theybe been molsted and tried to tell me they were doing whats best for my kids...i wanted to make them go thru what they made my kids and i go thru really but wven tho have wronged us so bad im not that kinda person. They robbed us of hope and a futur together.

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My son rarely sees some of his siblings. It has absolutely taken away a lot of should be memories.

— CHRISTINE

The system has destroyed our way of life and made life a struggle for us because we are forced to spend time with and have to co-parent with our abuser. He continues to emotionally and verbally abuse our daughters and attempts to do the same to me. Luckily years of counseling has taught me how to ignore his attempts. I have been forced to stay in a state with no family or support system. My health has greatly suffered from all the stress. I have an autoimmune disease that will never go away and will haunt me for the rest of my life because of the way he treated me and our girls. He took something from me that I can never get back despite tons of evidence that the judge refused to look at. I was never given any post separation support despite being a dependent spouse for 12 years so my credit was ruined and I struggled financially for years and am still trying to recover from the financial destruction he has caused me. Our daughters are teenagers now and very angry. They were forced to go from the life they knew to a total opposite change of what they knew literally over night. The stress they went through and are continuing to experience is horrible and so unfair to them.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They tore my children out of a loving safe home.... This distorted my whole life.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Hell right here on earth every second of every day non stop torture

— JENNIFER

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The system openly ignored the fact that my children were being exposed to Marijuana - being used in front of children in an illegal state, unhealthy living conditions, unsafe sleeping arrangements and had a lack of proper hygiene and grooming, to keep the children in a town their "entire lives were spent in" the oldest was 5. The judge simple ignored all evidence due to the fact I was planning to move to a different state were both myself and them would have family support.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Turns out "family court " forgot the family part . Best interest of the child" sounds good, but in practice, it can feel like budgets and procedure matter more than children's actual needs. We lived the gap between the slogan and the reality. Children deserve more than a slogan .

— BECKA

Caused depression and PTSD, living in constant flight or fight

— TAMEKA

Taken my child through an emergency order riddled with false allegations and indicated she was adaptable for placement families....held her in cps custody over 1 year with still no hearing to date

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This is not a system to protect children, it is a system of lies and manipulation to obtain funds which ever way they can extort it!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has alienated me from my children and their lives. It has denied my children of their mother and the close relationship we once had. The system doesn't care about "the best interest" of the children, they care about continuing the cycle for profit. Judges are not held accountable for perjuring themselves. They say one thing and do another. This system is a joke.

— ALEXIS

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The system put my child in the custody of an abusive grandparent who isolates her from me and other loving people

— MANDY

I've witnessed a very unfair and concerning amount of corruption in this court room as a witness. I am deeply concerned for the justice system in this county and have lost faith in honorable decision making.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed our family, testimony should not be believed without evidence to support. Family court should be held accountable and rules changed to what is allowed- not who they believe more, Narcissist protect their image.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has caused my children to be scared of the government. Non-trusting of people and scared to develop relationships with good people. Also my son has been abused while in their custody and he is very angry and will cut people out of his life quickly. These were happy, well- adjusted, loving children, going through this has left scars no one can see but I can feel every day.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I can't protect my kids from their abusive father. It was very clear to me in family court that because I was accusing my ex of being violent, I was immediately seen to be the problem, as though I was making accusations simply to get full custody of my kids.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They have made me lose so many first milestones with my son I've missed school pictures, yearbooks, first tooth, field day, dances, programs, Christmases. He's missed his brother's graduation.

— CHRISTINE

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The Charlotte-Mecklenburg Judiciary has cost me over 6 years of an already horrific, adjudicated system of ABUSE. Irena Zarutka put this county on the map with it's bad behavior and sadly, that women, who lost her life has seemingly crossed over to a better place than this town. This town should be exposed for its injustice. (Is there an email I can provide with all of my story that I sent to ACLU?)

— KRISTEN

I was wrongful accused and DSS has no proof of allegations. My oldest daughter came home. But the youngest is still being alienated from me

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Severe prolonged psychological damage and traumatic mental health physical deterioration. PTSD, depression near death. Tremendous strain and stress near loss of external family. Word's can't describe. Death. Death of hope. Stroke, heart attack, seizures job loss reputation destruction online repetition slander reputation destruction resulting in joblessness and in a few weeks homelessness.

— TRAVIS

Alienated me from constitutional fatherhood and the quiet enjoyment thereof

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Since my child has been in public schools I, have had multiple cases opened. I have even had multiple cases opened in the same week.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Completely tore apart

— HEATHER

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Tried to rip us apart as in they tried to make my husband and I divorce told us that they had someone that wanted to adopt our children. We presume it was my in-laws because they've been trying to get me to sign my son over to them

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Multiple counties conspired together to destroy my home and peace of mind.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ruined our entire life!!!

— BRITNY

The family court system has broken my faith in the American Justice system, hurt my mental health, my family's savings is gone letting mine and my child's abuser win absolutely everything. A man that hasn't seen or talked to his child in 2 years and hurt him has full and complete custody a man with 100% disability mostly from severe mental health.

— REBECCA

I have developed an autoimmune disorder. I have lost a ton of friends and hair. I have high blood pressure and trouble sleeping. I have started blood pressure medication and sleeping medicine. I'm only 31.

— TORI

It has affected my mental and emotional state. I feel like I am losing hope and not being treated like a human being. My Son is my reason for everything and now that he is gone I feel like I have nothing left in this world.

— CHELSEA

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

My son who is taking college courses in highschool is a good kid but has to endure his father's rage episodes where he has been strangled, pushed and father held my son down on the ground with his foot, banged his head on the desk, and threatened since 11 he would go to a foster home if he told police the abuse he was getting.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has ruined my life I have PTSD and severe Depression I'm lost and have no purpose. My daughter's are having separation anxiety issues and my special needs daughter doesn't understand what happened but knows something isn't right and her medical needs are now a fight daily with my mother in law because I know what's best and what she needs. My girls love me and my oldest daughter asks me daily if I am working on it?... meaning am I going to bring the ones who hurt us to justice.

— BRITTANY

This system has nearly broken me as an individual. I have never understood how people could give up on life and commit suicide until going through this experience as well as have I never had the true feeling of hatred towards anyone in my entire life and it's been very difficult to not feel that way towards these actors and perpetrators

— DANIEL

The system encouraged me to consent to a PC however gave me no choice in who I could use and has forced me to stay involved with AND pay a party who is clearly biased in regards to any interpretations of the order. I attempted to wait until the appointment was over rather than file motions to challenge PC decisions for the sake of peace and rather at a reappointment hearing, the PC was praised for keeping my family out of court. When I challenged that narrative the script was turned on me for not filing motions to challenge PC decisions. There is a documented pattern of preference. The PC substantially increased conflict in my family rather than lessen or resolve it.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

70 full approved North Carolina comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this North Carolina report comes from North Carolina respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in North Carolina — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 103 North Carolina families reporting here are not the universe of North Carolina families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

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Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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